

The Character Sheet Code

For Storytellers, a character sheet is basically a coded message, telling her what kinds of situations a player wants to encounter. A character with high Physical Attributes and a lot of fighting prowess wants to be tested in battle, a character with excellent Knowledge ratings is just begging to be served up some mysteries, and so on. For that matter, seeing what is absent from a character sheet can serve just as well, showing what sorts of challenges a character will be hard-pressed to overcome. If a Storyteller ever needs a quick idea for some possible scenes, there are worse ways than to simply look over the group's character sheets and think about how to tie together their various strengths and weaknesses.

For one thing, you can find countless fictional examples of groups containing two or more members who can't stand each other at first, but wind up becoming close companions after shared hardship and adventures. Suggesting this model to the players can actually be the beginning of a really amazing roleplaying journey, as the *players* work to bring their characters closer together over time even though their *characters* can't possibly imagine such an outcome when they first meet.

Another thing to remember about clashing characters is that some tension and discord in the group can be a really fun element to roleplay, but only so long as it is kept in character. Players whose characters clash must take care to always keep such conflicts in game, and not take it personally. Provided they can do that, having bickering characters or characters who are seriously at odds only adds to the drama of the adventure and can lead to some very engaging roleplaying during the chronicle.

Ultimately, players of clashing characters should bear in mind that unless the group has specifically agreed to allow intense player vs. player actions, their disagreements should ultimately not break up the character group, but be used more for color and roleplaying tension. After all, while discord can be good for drama, actually derailing the game due to excessive conflict between characters can leave the rest of the group feeling a bit frustrated out of game.

Building A Setting

Characters don't exist in a vacuum, and the choice of a setting has a major impact on a lot of the chronicle's most basic elements. A game set in a small town in middle America during the early 1960s is going to be very different from a game set in the punk subculture of modern London, for example, and both are substantially different from a game set in a freehold overlooking a remote mountain town in Alaska.

Some Storytellers may wish to handle the setting process entirely on their own, so that they can build it to suit their chronicle's needs precisely, but unless this is truly necessary it's

a good idea to work with the players to help design a setting together. Doing so removes some of the burden of a complicated process from resting entirely on the Storyteller, for one thing, and for another having a hand in designing the setting makes the players immediately invested, in much the same way as character-driven story design, discussed previously.

One of the easiest ways to approach setting creation is to start off with a very basic notion of where the game might take place, such as "a city" or "somewhere in the wilderness." The Storyteller may wish to control this aspect, such as specifying a particular city or certain area of wilderness if she wants to steer things in a certain direction, or she can leave it up to the players. For example, she may feel that a city is the best place for the story she has in mind, but not be too particular about which city, leaving that up to the players with room for her to customize around whatever metropolis they decide upon.

If all of the players are not familiar with the chosen setting, it's a good idea to get everyone up to speed with some basics — pictures, maps, a little bit of a history lesson, whatever might help them visualize where the game will be taking place. If the setting is mostly or entirely fictional, it's best to make sure everyone understands what it's like and has a feel for the place. It doesn't have to involve creating hours of detailed background, just enough detail to get a sense of what the setting is like to start is fine. Drawing real-world comparisons helps, too, whether it means showing the skyline of one city, some famous landmarks from another, or otherwise grounding it at least somewhat in reality.

Soliciting suggestions from the players for interesting locations is another good way for a Storyteller to involve them during this process. Once the basic setting has been decided upon and the players have a rough idea of what it's like, go around the table and have everyone pitch in an idea for a place that might turn up during play. It can be something personal, like a character's house or school, or it can be something broader, like a local landmark or watering hole. It can even be something that the characters aren't aware of yet, but that the player thinks might be cool to explore, like a mysterious house at the edge of town or a strange grove in the forest. This sort of exercise can yield a rich bounty of plot hooks and character connections, not to mention help fill out the setting's map right from the start.

Another element of setting design is the cast of supporting characters that the players' characters will encounter during the story. While the Storyteller may have a few in mind already, going around the table and having players suggest supporting characters in the same style as interesting locations can be a quick and effective way to help populate the setting with a diverse and compelling cast. Not to mention providing a number of ready-made personalities that the Storyteller can fall back on as needed.

Last but not least, it's definitely worth talking about whether the players are the only motley in town, or merely a segment of a larger fae population. Being the only changelings in the area makes for a very intimate game, but can also limit certain setting elements like Kithain politics and antagonists, as well as the ability to use supporting characters to illustrate